



STREET FIGHTS

# The Amazon Bike-Truck Has Been an Adjustment



By Clio Chang, a Curbed writer who covers everything New York City

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The Amazon bike-trucks have been pedaling around the city for a while now, but they're still a curiosity. When I notice one sailing through Brooklyn Heights on a crisp day in September, I consider its weird little construction: It has four wheels and a tall trailer, which make it look like a truck. But it also looks like a bike because the driver pedals it, usually in the bike lane. It's an ingenious contraption, built for last-mile deliveries in crowded city streets, but it's arguably too big for existing bike lanes and too slow for the street, so everyone in the city seems to get mad about its presence wherever it is. "Even though I'm pedaling, cyclists will yell at me to get out of the bike lane," the driver (rider?) of one in Brooklyn Heights tells me after stopping for a delivery. But the same thing happens when he's in the street, he says. Drivers yell at him because he's slower than a car.

I find another delivery guy pulled up in front of a hydrant on Atlantic Avenue stopping for a lunch break. People yell at him, too. "They tell me to get out of the lane and curse at me," he said of cyclists. "But I feel way safer in the bike lane." Later, in Manhattan, I watch as another delivery driver weaves her Amazon e-cargo bike through traffic on Lexington Avenue — looking like a little rickshaw next to actual trucks — and I see his point.

New York fights a lot about its streets — bike lanes, dedicated bus lanes, parking, micro-hubs, road diets (which may live or die over a promised appearance on *Blue Bloods*). But the debate over the Amazon e-cargo bikes is a little different. The issue seems to hinge, both existentially and practically, on a simple question: What is a bicycle? When the Department of Transportation first announced its decision to allow these vehicles in the bike lanes, it had to amend the definition of a bicycle to include "pedal-assist commercial" devices that have up to four wheels. Was this madness? ("These are stupid," one person wrote on Reddit. "They are not bicycles. Prefix is 'bi' meaning two.") More than a year after their rollout, these vehicles have made an uneasy transition into the landscape, but they are also doing exactly what they are supposed to do — sub in for the delivery trucks and vans that are arguably just as annoying and much more dangerous.

The release of the bike-truck has been a few years in the making. The city first began piloting these cargo e-bikes in 2019 and has been honing the rules governing them in the years since. (There were some notable hiccups; an earlier Amazon prototype tipped over because it was too tall.) The discussion around them was, like all things street-space related, contentious. During one public rulemaking call held by the city, over 100 cyclists, pedestrian-safety advocates, cargo-bike-trailer users, and other community-meeting types weighed in: "It's the end of bike lanes," one attendee said. Another added, "I've never been scared here until now." But it wasn't all opposition: Some people at the meeting pointed out the positive changes the bikes could bring about. "Smaller cargo bikes not only free up space on our congested roadways, they improve traffic safety by removing bulky and heavy trucks from the streets," Elizabeth Adams, the deputy director for public affairs at Transportation Alternatives, said.

The DOT forged ahead, finally settling on the rules last year: The city expanded the bikes' allowable size — they can now be 16 feet long, four feet wide, and seven feet high — but they're not permitted to be on the sidewalk, even when making deliveries. They can go up to only 15 miles per hour, the same speed as an electric Citi Bike. (The Amazon bikes are even slower, going up to only 12 miles per hour.) It's still early, and there aren't specific traffic and safety data on the cargo e-bikes, but the DOT pointed out that, overall, injuries to cyclists and the people riding e-bikes, mopeds, and scooters are so far trending down — which is good. And judging from how they're used elsewhere, these delivery bikes are a much safer, less polluting, and more efficient way to deliver all the junk we order online. One study of cargo bikes in Europe showed they delivered packages 60 percent faster than vans in city centers. And according to the DOT, it takes just two trips for a large cargo bike to transport the same load as a delivery truck.

Given all that, it's clear the e-cargo bikes aren't the issue, not really. The city's infrastructure just hasn't caught up to our new reality — or it has refused to. The problems with the vehicles were wholly predictable; wider or separate bike lanes would fix most cyclists' gripes. “Everyone that isn't a car in New York City is fighting for the same five inches of space,” as Alexa Sledge, spokesperson for Transportation Alternatives, put it. “All of this fighting could entirely be avoided if we just allocated street space in accordance to how people are actually using the streets.” And while the city has installed wider lanes on a number of avenues in Manhattan and this summer debuted a 16-foot-wide boulevard on 31st Avenue in Astoria, these lanes are still not the norm. (When I asked one Amazon driver about the prospect of wider bike lanes, he lit up: “That would make a *huge* difference.”)

So what's Amazon saying about all this? Not much. Despite how integral our streets are to the company's model, no one there wanted to comment on the question of wider bike lanes. And while we've seen how quickly private industry can speed up city priorities in other projects, when I asked Sledge if she thought Amazon might advocate for the infrastructure its drivers and riders need, she was skeptical. “I'm not holding my breath,” she said. She pointed to how same-day-delivery apps like Instacart that also take up the bike lanes have actively fought against safety regulations for their drivers: “It is the job squarely of DOT and the mayor to build the infrastructure we need.”

In the absence of that, cyclists and other riders are left to fight over the lanes we have. Or over what even counts as a bike. I ask one delivery driver how he would categorize his vehicle; he stands and ponders it for a moment. “I have to pedal it, and the cars are way faster,” he said. But the thing that really seals its bikeness for him? “I have to do deliveries around Dumbo a lot, and I hate going over the cobblestones.”

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